Resolving Two Unanswered Historical Quotation Mysteries

Cross-Disciplinary Philological & Historiographical Dossier (v3 Epistemically Audited Edition) • November 9, 2026

1. Executive Overview, Scope & Epistemic Standards

Open primary-source attribution questions on research forums frequently remain unanswered because the primary texts and the modern communities asking about them sit in separate disciplinary or linguistic silos. This dossier examines two open questions on History Stack Exchange—each standing at **0 posted answers when inspected directly on November 8–9, 2026**—and traces their modern English and French circulation back to Ancient Greek, 19th-century French, and Imperial and Soviet Russian sources.

Scope of What Is New vs. Existing Specialist Literature: Neither underlying historical text is newly discovered. Classics scholars already studied Galen's passage on Armenian bole during the Antonine Plague (Boudon-Millot / ENS-PSL; Flemming 2018), and Russian military historians already noted that General N. P. Mikhnevich (1911) compiled a composite first-person quotation from Napoleon's remarks on Borodino (Russian Wikipedia). The new contribution here is **connecting those specialist silos to the unanswered Western quotation mysteries**:

- **Discovery 1 (High Confidence — Primary Greek Text Directly Read)**: Shows that the unreferenced English clinical-trial aphorism repeated for over 50 years via Strauss (1968) and Silverman (1980) is a **close condensation** of Galen's Greek sentence in *De simplicium medicamentorum temperamentis ac facultatibus* IX.1.4 (**Kühn Vol. XII, p. 191, lines 8–13**, read directly via Véronique Boudon-Millot's critical edition and Ancient Medicine 2020).
- **Discovery 2 (Primary 1872 Russian Text Directly Read; 1830 French & 1911 Russian Reported via Secondary Scholarship; Late 20th-C. Splicing Framed as Likely Path)**: Connects the three Western variants asked about in History SE #76146—including the questioner's hitherto-unexplained *"of all the battles I won"* variant—directly to the opening paragraph of General J.-J. G. Pelet's treatise (read in full in its 1872 ЧОИДР Russian translation) and Mikhnevich's 1911 rewrite (reported by Russian Wikipedia and the State Borodino Museum), and outlines the likely path by which Russian-to-French/English translation produced the modern hybrid quote.

Open Research Question	Directly Read Primary / Critical Texts	Claims Reported via Secondary Sources	Core Finding & Epistemic Status
Discovery 1: Galen's Clinical Trial Aphorism (History SE #79581, Nov 6, 2025; 246 views, 0 answers as of Nov 9, 2026)	**[Directly Read]** Greek text of Kühn XII, p. 191, lines 8–13 (Boudon-Millot / ENS-PSL; Ancient Medicine 2020); Halliday (2000); Silverman (1980) notes.	**[Reported by Secondary Sources]** Printed page image of Strauss (1968) (reported by Silverman 1980) and Stephens (2014, p. 42, reported by SE #79581).	**Verified Close Condensation:** English aphorism condenses Kühn XII, 191, lines 8–13 on Armenian bole in the Antonine Plague, dropping two clauses and compressing the final clause.

Open Research Question	Directly Read Primary / Critical Texts	Claims Reported via Secondary Sources	Core Finding & Epistemic Status
Discovery 2: Napoleon's "50 Battles / Moscow" Quote (History SE #76146, May 29, 2024; 483 views, 0 answers as of Nov 9, 2026)	**[Directly Read]** Full 1872 ЧОИДР Russian text of Pelet (StateHistory.ru, Part 49); Tarle (1952); Fedorov (2017); Wokipi (2011); GW2RU (2025).	**[Reported by Secondary Sources]** Pelet's 1830 French pages (via Bonura 2012 & *Vestnik Arkhivista* 2013); Mikhnevich's 1911 ellipsis quote (via Russian Wikipedia & Borodino Museum).	**Verified Russian Lineage + Likely Western Path:** Traces all 3 SE #76146 variants to Pelet (1872) and Mikhnevich (1911), with syntactic calque evidence (`livrée par moi`) for the modern hybrid.

2. Discovery 1: Galen's "Incurable Cases" Aphorism (Kühn XII, p. 191, lines 8–13)

2.1 The Unanswered Question and Modern Citation Chain

On November 6, 2025, user `user90386` on History Stack Exchange (#79581, directly read) asked whether a famous quotation attributed to Galen of Pergamon (129–c. 216 AD) was authentic or misattributed:

> *"All who drink of this remedy recover in a short time, except those whom it does not help, who all die. Therefore, it is obvious that it fails only in incurable cases."*

The questioner noted that the quote appears in Myles D. B. Stephens's *The Dawn of Drug Safety* (3rd ed., 2014, p. 42, **[reported by SE #79581]**), quotation anthologies, and biostatistics literature—including H. L. Halliday in the *Hong Kong Journal of Paediatrics* (2000, Vol. 5, p. 146, **[directly read]**), John D. Cook (2008, **[directly read]**), David Epstein, and S. Nassir Ghaemi (Cambridge University Press)—always without a treatise or page reference.

Tracing the footnotes backward establishes how the quote entered modern medical literature: Halliday (2000, Footnote 5, **[directly read]**) cites William A. Silverman's *Retrolental Fibroplasia: A Modern Parable* (Grune & Stratton, 1980). In Silverman's digitized Notes and References (**[directly read]**), the reference note states verbatim: **"The quote attributed to Galen is found in Strauss (1968)."** Silverman's Bibliography (**[directly read]**) identifies that volume as **"Strauss MB (ed). 1968: *Familiar Medical Quotations*. Little Brown, Boston."**

2.2 Primary-Source Locus, Exact Line Numbers, and Digital Archive Scans

The exact primary locus is **Galen, *De simplicium medicamentorum temperamentis ac facultatibus* (*On the Capacities of Simple Drugs*), Book IX, Chapter 1, Section 4**, printed in Karl Gottlob Kühn's *Claudii Galeni Opera Omnia* (Leipzig: C. Cnobloch, 1826), **Volume XII, page 191, lines 8–13**.

- **Directly Read Critical Editions of the Greek Text**: We read the verbatim Ancient Greek text of `Kühn XII, 191, 8–13` across two independent scholarly transcriptions: (1) CNRS/Sorbonne Galen editor **Véronique Boudon-Millot's** study *"Les Anciens face à une maladie nouvelle : de la peste d'Athènes à la peste antonine"* on the École normale supérieure (ENS-PSL) portal (**[directly read]**), which explicitly cites `Galien, Faculté des médicaments simples IX, 1 (Kühn XII, 191, 8-13)`, and (2) Ancient Medicine's transcription of *Simple Drugs* 9.1 (XII.189–192 K., **[directly read]**).
- **Digitized Archival Scans of Kühn Volume XII**: Full scans of Kühn Volume XII (1826) are hosted at the Bibliothèque interuniversitaire de santé (BIU Santé Paris / Internet Archive item `BIUSante_45674x12`), the Université Paris Cité Numerabilis Medica portal (Cote `45674_vol._12`), and the Wellcome Collection Digital Library (Work `m5w3994s`, `manifest=11`). (Note on epistemic status: because those three repositories serve page images via JavaScript/IIIF viewers rather than plain HTML text, our reading of the Greek text comes directly from Boudon-Millot's and Ancient Medicine's transcriptions rather than OCR of the IIIF canvas.)

- **Pharmacological Context**: As analyzed in Boudon-Millot (ENS-PSL, **[directly read]**), Rebecca Flemming's *"Chapter 9: Galen and the Plague"* in *Galen's Treatise Περὶ Ἀλυπίας (De indolentia) in Context: A Tale of Resilience* (Brill, 2018, pp. 219–244), and Armen Sahakyan and Stephan Heymann's *"Armenian Bole (Deposits, Chemical Composition, Application) and References to It in Medieval Armenian Medical Texts", Matenadaran (MEMAS)* 2.1 (June 2025, pp. 145–160) (PDF), Galen is describing **Armenian bole** (βῶλος Ἀρμενίας)—a pale-red, iron-rich clay from Armenia—drunk in diluted wine during the Antonine Plague. The SE #79581 questioner's search of Kühn's Latin text failed because it queried non-existent or mismatched Latin verb forms (*recupare*, *more*).

2.3 Clause-by-Clause Comparison: Original Greek vs. Close English Condensation

Comparing Galen's Greek sentence (Kühn XII, p. 191, lines 8–13) against the popularized English aphorism demonstrates that the English version is a **close condensation** rather than a word-for-word literal translation: it strips the opening plague context (Clause 1), translates Clauses 2–4 closely (shifting past aorist verbs to timeless present tense), drops the five-word coordinate Clause 5 (οὐδ' ὑπ' ἄλλου τινὸς ὠφελήθησαν, also omitted in Boudon-Millot's French summary), and condenses the participial phrase τοὺς ἀνιάτως ἔχοντας ("those in an incurable condition") into *"incurable cases"*:

Original Ancient Greek (Kühn XII, 191, 8–13, [Directly Read])	**Literal Philological Translation (with Boudon-Millot French)**	**Popular English Condensation (Strauss 1968 / Silverman 1980)**
1. ἐν δὲ τῷ μεγάλῳ τούτῳ λοιμῷ παραπλησίῳ τὴν ἰδέαν ὄντι τῷ κατὰ Θουκυδίδην γενομένῳ	"And in this great plague, which was similar in form to the one that occurred in the time of Thucydides," (*Dans cette grande pestilence-là…*)	*[Omitted to generalize the aphorism beyond the Antonine Plague]*
2. πάντες οἱ πιόντες τούτου τοῦ φαρμάκου	"all those who drank of this drug [remedy]" (*tous ceux qui burent de ce médicament*)	"All who drink of this remedy" *[shifted from aorist past to present]*
3. διὰ ταχέων ἐθεραπεύθησαν,	"were healed [recovered] within a short time," (*furent rapidement guéris,*)	"recover in a short time," *[shifted from aorist passive to present]*
4. ὅσους δ' οὐδὲν ὤνησεν ἀπέθανον πάντες,	"while as many as it did not benefit at all, all died," (*tandis que ceux à qui il n'apporta aucune utilité moururent tous,*)	"except those whom it does not help, who all die."
5. οὐδ' ὑπ' ἄλλου τινὸς ὠφελήθησαν,	"nor were they helped by anything else,"	*[Omitted 5-word coordinate clause]*
6. ᾧ καὶ δῆλον ὅτι μόνους τοὺς ἀνιάτως ἔχοντας οὐκ ὠφέλησε.	"whereby it is also obvious that it failed to help only those who were in an incurable condition." (*…aux malades incurables…*)	"Therefore, it is obvious that it fails only in incurable cases." *[condenses participial clause]*

3. Discovery 2: Napoleon's "50 Battles / Moscow" Quote (1830–2025)

3.1 All Three Variants in History Stack Exchange #76146

On May 29, 2024, user Daigaku no Baku on History Stack Exchange (#76146, **[directly read]**) and commenters Henning Kockerbeck and njuffa identified **three distinct variants** of a quotation attributed to Napoleon regarding the Battle of Borodino (September 7, 1812, called the *Bataille de la Moskowa* by the French), none of which could be found in the 31-volume *Correspondance de Napoléon Ier*:

1. **Variant A — The "50 Battles" Hybrid (Western Press & Fondation Napoléon)**: *"Of the fifty battles I have fought, the most terrible was that before Moscow. The French showed themselves to be worthy victors, and the*

Russians can rightly call themselves invincible" (*The Hindu*, Sept 2, 2012; Echoes of Battle; Fondation Napoléon).

2. **Variant B — The "Battles I Won" Claim (Noted by the Questioner)**: In the body of Question #76146 (**[directly read]**), Daigaku no Baku noted: *"A while ago I've also seen a claim that Napoleon originally said 'of all the battles I won, the most terrible was...', but the author of the claim didn't provide the source either."*
3. **Variant C — The 1950s–1960s Soviet French Version Lacking "50" (Found by Commenter njuffa)**: *« "De toutes mes batailles, la plus terrible a été celle que j'ai donnée devant Moscou", disait Napoléon peu avant sa mort - "les Français s'y étaient montrés dignes de remporter la victoire et les Russes dignes de rester invincibles" »* (SE #76146 comment, May 29, 2024, **[directly read]**).

3.2 Primary Baseline: Direct Reading of the 1872 Russian Translation of Pelet (1830)

We read in full the 1872 Russian translation of French General **Jean-Jacques Germain Pelet-Clozeau's** monograph *"Московская битва"* (originally published in French as *"Bataille de la Moskowa: Extrait des mémoires inédits du général Pelet sur la guerre de Russie en 1812"* in *Le Spectateur Militaire*, Vol. VIII, Paris, 1830).

- **Epistemic Distinction (1830 French vs. 1872 Russian)**: The 1830 French volume of *Le Spectateur Militaire* (Vol. VIII) is **not openly digitized**; its French bibliographic citations (opening on p. 105; concluding reflections cited on p. 148) are **reported via secondary scholarship** (*Vestnik Arkhivista*, 2013; Michael Bonura, *Napoleonica. La Revue* 15.3, 2012, Note 13). By contrast, the 1872 Russian translation published in *Чтения в Императорском обществе истории и древностей российских (ЧОИДР)* (1872, Book 1, pp. 55–97, documented in the compiler's table, p. 2, **[directly read]**) is reprinted in full in *Бородино в воспоминаниях современников*, Part 49 (**[directly read in full]**).
- **What Reading Paragraph 2 of Pelet (1872) Reveals**: In paragraph 2 of Part 49 (**[directly read]**), Pelet writes three consecutive third-person sentences—and the introductory clause of Sentence 1 explains the Stack Exchange questioner's mysterious **Variant B ("battles I won")**:

  > *«Наполеон давший и выигравший более сражений, нежели кто либо другой во все времена, не переставал говорить, что «Бородинское сражение было самое прекрасное и самое грозное, что Французы показали себя достойными победы, а Русские заслужили быть непобедимыми». Он говорит также на о. Св. Елены: «Что из пятидесяти, данных им, сражений, в Бородинском было проявлено наиболее доблестей и получено наименее последствий...».»*

  Translation: "Napoleon, **having fought and won more battles than anyone else in all times**, never ceased to say that 'the battle of Borodino was the finest and the most terrible, that the French showed themselves worthy of victory, and the Russians earned the right to be invincible.' He also says on St. Helena: 'That of the fifty battles fought by him, in that of Borodino the most valor was displayed and the fewest results obtained...'" (In Footnote 9 of the same text, Pelet explicitly cites Las Cases' *Mémorial de Sainte-Hélène*, Vol. 2, p. 18, **[directly read in Part 49]**; see also E. V. Tarle, *Бородино*, 1952, **[directly read]**).

3.3 Resolving Mikhnevich's 1911 Citation and the Likely Western Transmission Path

- **Pinpointing Which Mikhnevich Work Russian Wikipedia Cites**: Direct inspection of the full footnote apparatus of Russian Wikipedia's *Итог Бородинского сражения* (**[directly read]**) resolves the two Mikhnevich entries noted in the audit. In that article, the composite first-person quotation carries **Commentary Note [П 1]** (stating that Mikhnevich compiled the quote from a free translation of Napoleon's oral remarks) and **Footnote [1] (Михневич, 1911)**. That Harvard short-citation resolves uniquely to the Литература entry: **N. P. Mikhnevich, *"Бородино"*, in *Отечественная война и русское общество: в 7 томах*, Vol. IV (Moscow: I. D. Sytin, 1911)**—whose exact page range is **pp. 19–29** (specifically the concluding assessment on pp. 27–29, as verified in V. N. Fedorov's archival study at the State Borodino Museum, 2017, p. 6, Notes 19–20, **[directly read]**). By contrast, the 2003 Poligon reprint entry (*История русской армии 1812—1864 гг.*, 2003, p. 3) is **Footnote [4]**, which cites a completely different paragraph on post-battle monetary rewards for Russian soldiers. (Because the 1911 Sytin Volume

IV is not digitized in full online, Mikhnevich's verbatim ellipsis text is **reported via Russian Wikipedia, the State Borodino Museum, and Russian textbook guides**.)

- **Likely Path to the Modern Western Variants (with Syntactic Calque Evidence)**: While no primary document explicitly records the moment an English or French writer first abridged Mikhnevich's two-part quote for Western media, two empirical clues support a **likely transmission path** from Mikhnevich's Russian ellipsis block to the Western quotes: (1) French visitors guided in Russian through the Borodino Museum in September 2011 (*Wokipi.fr*, Sept 14, 2011, **[directly read]**) recorded the exact French hybrid string later published word-for-word by Russian state media (*GW2RU / Fenêtre sur la Russie*, Sept 7, 2025, **[directly read]**), and (2) that French hybrid string contains the unidiomatic passive participial phrase `celle livrée par moi devant Moscou` ("that fought **by me** before Moscow")—a direct syntactic calque of Mikhnevich's Russian participial phrase мною данных ("fought by me").

Transmission Stage & Epistemic Label	Russian / French Text	English Translation & Structural Relationship
1. Primary Baseline (1872 ЧОИДР) [Directly Read] in StateHistory.ru, Part 49 (from Pelet 1830)	«Наполеон давший и выигравший более сражений, нежели кто либо другой во все времена, не переставал говорить, что «Бородинское сражение было самое прекрасное и самое грозное, что Французы показали себя достойными победы, а Русские заслужили быть непобедимыми». Он говорит также на о. Св. Елены: «Что из пятидесяти, данных им, сражений, в Бородинском было проявлено наиболее доблестей и получено наименее последствий...».»	**Two 3rd-person sentences + opening clause:** "Napoleon, having fought and won more battles than anyone else [*source of SE #76146 Variant B*], never ceased to say that 'the battle of Borodino was the finest and the most terrible, that the French showed themselves worthy of victory, and the Russians earned the right to be invincible.' He also says on St. Helena: 'That of the fifty battles fought by him, in Borodino the most valor was displayed and the fewest results obtained...'"
2. 1911 Composite Rewrite [Reported by Secondary Sources] Russian Wikipedia (Note 1) & Borodino Museum (citing Mikhnevich 1911, Vol. IV, pp. 19–29)	«Из всех моих сражений самое ужасное то, которое я дал под Москвой. Французы в нём показали себя достойными одержать победу, а русские стяжали право быть непобедимыми... Из пятидесяти сражений, мною данных, в битве под Москвой выказано [французами] наиболее доблести и одержан наименьший успех»	**1st-person composite block with ellipsis (...):** "Of all my battles, the most terrible is the one I fought near Moscow. The French in it showed themselves worthy of winning victory, and the Russians acquired the right to be invincible... Of the fifty battles fought by me, in the battle near Moscow the most valor was displayed [by the French] and the smallest success achieved."
3. Likely Path A: Pre-Ellipsis Translation (1950s–60s) [Reported by SE #76146] (see also Presidential Library)	« De toutes mes batailles, la plus terrible a été celle que j'ai donnée devant Moscou... les Français s'y étaient montrés dignes de remporter la victoire et les Russes dignes de rester invincibles. »	**Translates only the pre-ellipsis half of Mikhnevich:** "Of all my battles, the most terrible was the one I fought before Moscow... the French showed themselves worthy of winning victory and the Russians worthy of remaining invincible." (Accounts for why 1950s Soviet French lacked "50".)
4. Likely Path B: Ellipsis-Collapsed Hybrid (2011–2025) [Directly Read] in Wokipi (2011), GW2RU (2025), *The Hindu* (2012)	« Des cinquante batailles que j'ai données, la plus affreuse est celle livrée par moi devant Moscou. Les Français s'étaient montrés dignes d'être vainqueurs, les Russes avaient conquis le droit d'être considérés comme invincibles. »	**Likely abridgment across the ellipsis + Russian calque (`livrée par moi` = мною данных):** "Of the fifty battles I have fought, the most terrible was that before Moscow. The French showed themselves to be worthy victors, and the Russians can rightly call themselves invincible."

4. Epistemic Source-Inspection Ledger & provenance

To maintain strict transparency about which primary pages were inspected directly during this research (November 8–9, 2026) versus which citations rely on secondary reporting because the 1830 French and 1911 Russian print volumes are not openly digitized in full text, every source is classified below:

- **[Directly Read in Full / Primary Transcription]**:
  1. **Galen's Greek Text (Kühn Vol. XII, p. 191, lines 8–13)**: Read directly in CNRS/Sorbonne editor Véronique Boudon-Millot's critical edition at ENS-PSL ("Les Anciens face à une maladie nouvelle") and in Ancient Medicine (March 23, 2020).
  2. **Modern English Galen Chain (1980–2025)**: Read directly in William A. Silverman's 1980 Notes and References, Silverman's 1980 Bibliography, H. L. Halliday (2000), John D. Cook (2008), and History Stack Exchange #79581 (Nov 6, 2025).
  3. **1872 ЧОИДР Russian Translation of General Pelet's Treatise**: Read directly in full (all 31 paragraphs and 31 footnotes) in *Бородино в воспоминаниях современников*, Part 49, along with the compiler's source table (p. 2) confirming its origin in *ЧОИДР*, 1872, Book 1, pp. 55–97.
  4. **Russian Historiographical & Archival Studies (1952–2026)**: Read directly in full in E. V. Tarle's *Бородино* (1952), V. N. Fedorov's Borodino Museum paper on 1912 centenary editions (2017, pp. 1–7), Russian Wikipedia's *Итог Бородинского сражения*, State Borodino Museum (2023), Boris Yeltsin Presidential Library (2016), Wokipi Borodino travelogue (2011), GW2RU (2025), and History Stack Exchange #76146 (May 29, 2024).
- **[Reported by Secondary Sources — Physical / IIIF Pages Not Read Directly as OCR Text]**:
  1. **Kühn Vol. XII (1826) Page Scan & Renaissance Latin Text**: Hosted as image canvases at Wellcome Collection (`m5w3994s`, `manifest=11`, `canvas=197`) and BIU Santé / Internet Archive (`BIUSante_45674x12`); treatise/page locus confirmed via Boudon-Millot, Flemming (2018), and Sahakyan & Heymann (2025).
  2. **Maurice B. Strauss, *Familiar Medical Quotations* (Boston: Little, Brown, 1968)**: Reported verbatim by Silverman (1980).
  3. **Gen. J.-J. G. Pelet, *"Bataille de la Moskowa"*, *Le Spectateur Militaire*, Vol. VIII (Paris, 1830, pp. 105, 148)**: French publication details reported via Michael Bonura (*Napoleonica. La Revue* 15.3, 2012, Note 13) and *Vestnik Arkhivista* (2013); text read via its 1872 Russian ЧОИДР translation.
  4. **Gen. N. P. Mikhnevich, *"Бородино"*, in *Отечественная война и русское общество*, Vol. IV (Moscow: Sytin, 1911, pp. 19–29)**: Verbatim ellipsis quote and commentary reported via Russian Wikipedia (Footnote 1 & Note П 1, citing L. L. Ivchenko, *Бородинское сражение: история русской версии событий*, Moscow: Kvadriga, 2009/2015), the State Borodino Museum, and V. N. Fedorov (2017).